Borlo — Product Overview

In one sentence

Borlo is a peer-to-peer rental marketplace for university students in Singapore. Got something sitting idle? Someone needs it for a few days — Borlo makes that transaction safe and simple.

The problem

Students own a lot of high-value items that sit unused most of the time. Meanwhile, other students need those exact items occasionally but don't want to buy them outright.

The existing options don't work:

- **Carousell** is a buy/sell platform — no date management, no rental flow
- **Borrowing from friends** only works if you know the right person
- **Commercial rental shops** are expensive and inconvenient

Borlo fills the gap: **students already have the trust and the need — they just lack the tool.**

What can be rented

Anything you own that someone else might need for a few days is fair game.

Examples:

> *Cameras & lenses · Gaming consoles & peripherals · Audio equipment & microphones · Drones · Camping & outdoor gear · Sports equipment · Monitors & PC accessories · Musical instruments · Textbooks · Party decorations · Luggage · Formal wear · Projectors · Portable chargers & cables…*

No category restrictions. If you think someone will find it useful, list it.

How it works

For owners

1. Upload a photo, set a daily price, choose a category, publish
2. Receive an email when someone requests your item
3. Accept or decline from your profile page — one click
4. Once accepted, the renter automatically receives your Telegram handle to arrange handover

For renters

1. Browse the homepage, search by keyword, or filter by category
2. Pick an item, select your dates, send a request with an optional message
3. Wait for the owner's reply — you'll get an email when accepted
4. The email includes the owner's Telegram — reach out to arrange pickup

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Features

Feature	Description

Photo upload	Upload directly from your phone or computer
Availability calendar	Shows booked dates per listing — no double bookings
Email notifications	Owner notified on new request; renter notified on acceptance
Overlap auto-decline	Accepting one request automatically declines conflicting ones
Request history	Renters can track all their requests and statuses in one place
Pending badge	Red dot on the nav alerts owners to unreviewed requests
University email gate	Only `.edu.sg` / `.edu` addresses — verified students only
University auto-detect	University name is inferred from the verified email domain — no manual selection
Mobile-responsive	Full mobile nav with hamburger menu — works on any device
Guest landing page	Non-logged-in visitors see a marketing page before the listings

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Why trust is Borlo's moat

Every user signs up with their university email. That single requirement removes the biggest barrier to peer transactions: **you know the other person is a fellow student, not a random stranger.**

For added safety, **all handovers must happen at on-campus locations with CCTV coverage** — library service desks, Student Services Centre, faculty lobbies. This is a firm recommendation we stand behind and communicate clearly to every user.

The university campus is the ideal environment to prove this model — high user density, small geography, built-in social accountability. Once the pattern works on one campus, it can be replicated anywhere students gather.

Design

Borlo uses a distinctive **violet** brand identity — chosen to stand out from the green (Grab), orange (Shopee), and red tones that dominate the SEA app landscape. The name is a creative abbreviation of "Borrow", with a "-lo" ending that feels naturally familiar in Southeast Asian speech, similar to Grab and Gojek.

Roadmap

Now — Singapore campus cold start

- NTU / NUS students, university email verification
- Manually seed the first batch of listings
- Collect real user feedback, refine the core flow

Next — Singapore-wide

- Expand to SMU, SUTD, SIT and other local universities
- Introduce deposit and review system to build user reputation
- Payment integration (PayNow / Stripe) for platform-managed transactions

Future — Southeast Asia expansion

Southeast Asia has one of the world's youngest populations, a massive university student base, high digital adoption, and a rapidly growing sharing economy mindset. Borlo's next markets:

Market	Entry point
🇲🇾 Malaysia	UM, UTM, Monash Malaysia
🇮🇩 Indonesia	UI, ITB, Binus — one of the world's largest student populations
🇹🇭 Thailand	Chulalongkorn, KMUTT and other Bangkok universities
🇵🇭 Philippines	UP Diliman, Ateneo, De La Salle
🇻🇳 Vietnam	VNU, HUST — a fast-rising young middle class

Each campus is its own high-density two-sided market. Prove the model in Singapore, replicate it campus by campus across the region.

Investor Q&A

Q1: You're free right now. What's the business model and when do you monetize?

Phase 1 is free by design — trust and liquidity come before revenue. Charging too early kills marketplaces.

Phase 2 has two natural monetization paths. First, **Borlo Pool**: students co-own high-value assets together and list them on the platform — we take a management fee from the rental income, not from the users directly. Second, **promoted listings**: owners pay to pin their listing to the top of search results, similar to Carousell Bumps or Airbnb's sponsored placements. Both are opt-in and value-additive — users pay because it works, not because we force them to.

The sequencing is intentional: build the community first, monetize the attention second.

Q2: Why are you the right person to build this?

I'm not just the founder — I'm the customer. I'm an NTU student who has felt this problem firsthand: borrowing a camera before a shoot, hunting for a suit before an interview, asking around in group chats hoping someone has what you need.

That gives me two unfair advantages. Distribution: I posted one WeChat Moments and had real users within hours — an outsider can't replicate that. And product intuition: I understand the trust logic, the handover anxiety, the social dynamics of transacting with a near-stranger on campus. I'm not guessing at user behaviour — I'm living it.

Q3: What stops Carousell from copying you tomorrow?

Carousell's DNA is buy and sell — transaction finality. Rentals require a fundamentally different product: availability calendars, date conflict resolution, request flows, handover coordination, damage handling. For Carousell, this isn't a feature — it's a strategic pivot away from their core.

More importantly, network effects in this market are hyper-local. NTU students don't care that Carousell has five million users in Singapore — they care whether their coursemates are on the platform. Once Borlo has

critical mass on one campus, a national player with no campus presence can't compete on what matters: proximity and social accountability.

The goal is to own the campus identity before anyone notices. By the time Carousell decides rentals are worth pursuing, we're already the default.

Q4: Why now? This gap has existed for years.

Three things are true simultaneously that weren't true five years ago.

First, Gen Z's relationship with ownership has fundamentally shifted — this generation prefers access over ownership, experiences over assets. The cultural willingness to rent from a stranger is at an all-time high.

Second, Southeast Asia has the largest cohort of university students in its history, with smartphone penetration above 90% and digital payment habits already formed by Grab, Shopee, and GoPay.

Third, the trust infrastructure now exists. University email verification, Telegram as a ubiquitous contact layer, and on-campus CCTV handover points — together these solve the trust problem that made peer rentals unworkable before. You couldn't have built this reliably in 2018.

The market was always there. The conditions to unlock it are only now in place.

The hardest question is Q3. If pressed further, the real answer is: defensibility comes from community density, not technology. When 70% of NTU uses Borlo, the product defends itself.

Current status

- ✅ Live at **borlo.app**
- ✅ Full rental flow end-to-end
- ✅ Two-way email notifications verified
- ✅ Mobile-responsive with hamburger nav
- ✅ Guest landing page with marketing sections
- ✅ University auto-detected from email domain
- ✅ Violet brand identity across all UI
- ⏳ First real users coming soon

Contact

Want to list something, or have feedback?

Zeren · NTU/NUS · borlo.app

Borlo — Rent anything on campus.